2 Meeting skills

Lead-in

Some business practices may differ from country to country. Here are some questions to research if you are attending meetings in a different country:

1 How formal will the meeting be? Some meetings can be more informal, similar to discussions, while others will be clearly structured with a clearly defined focus and written agenda.

2 How will the meeting take place? When teams work in different geographic locations and time zones, meetings might be a mix of using teleconferencing, telephone and face-to-face interaction. In these scenarios, it is particularly important to make points clearly and to seek clarification when needed.

Introductions and opening

Welcoming participants	Thank you all for coming today. It's great to see you all here today. Thank you all for coming at such short notice.
Introducing participants	Does everyone know each other? Could we go round and say a little about our roles? Most of you know each other, but I'd also like to welcome Hannah from Marketing, who has kindly agreed to join us today.
Opening the meeting	If we're all here, let's get started. Since everyone is here now, let's begin. OK, let's start by looking at the first point on the agenda.
Stating the meeting objectives	We're here to discuss the new delivery software. The main focus/goal of this meeting is to hear your ideas about ways to improve customer care. You'll see from the agenda that we are here to agree changes to the ordering process. Has everyone had a chance to look at the agenda? By the end of this meeting, we should have ideas for our new advertising campaign.

Participation

Encouraging participation	Kayo, you have experience with this market. What are your thoughts? Klaus, it'd be useful to have your opinion on this. What do you think, Luiz? Christina, would you be able to explain the aim of the project? We'd like to hear everyone's ideas. Does anyone have anything to add? Could you expand on this point for us? Can you elaborate on that?
Brainstorming ideas	How about considering flexitime? Why don't we open the sales lines an hour earlier? It might be worth running a competition. Maybe we could carry out a survey? Have you considered speaking to the supplier? One/Another thing to consider is the quality of the product. One option might be to increase prices. Adding to that idea/what Amy said, we could also focus on locally grown products more.
Agreeing/ Disagreeing	That's a good point. That could work. That could be worth a try. We could give it a go. That's an interesting suggestion. Let's keep it in mind. I can see your point, but that would be very difficult to implement. An alternative view is that the team performed well in difficult circumstances. I'm not keen on the idea of replacing all our equipment. I'm not sure that would work. We seem to have agreement on some of the key points but not on all the details. We can all agree that (we want the project to be successful).
Clarifying and asking for clarification	By that, I mean we need to increase the budget. What I'm trying to say is, I'm not sure that would work. To put it another way, we need to cut costs. Can I check what you mean by 'extend the schedule'? Sorry, I didn't catch that. Could you go over that again, please? Can I check that I understood that point correctly?

Managing a meeting

Keeping to the point	We seem to have moved away from the subject. Let's get back to the main topic, shall we? So what's your main point, Ana? Let's talk more about that next time we meet. This is not on today's agenda, so let's leave it for our next meeting. I'm afraid we'll have to come back to this later.
Managing time	We're running out of time, so we need to move on to the next point. Perhaps we need to discuss that topic in a separate meeting? Time is pressing, so let's make a decision. That's all the time we have on this topic. We have a lot to discuss, so can we keep to the agenda and save any additional points for the end?
Managing interruptions	Let's hear some other views on this. We'll come to you next, Sonja. Amal, please continue with what you were saying. We'll come to that point in a moment, Mario. Let's let Ben finish his point.

Discussing performance

Discussing what went well	Let's start with the positives. Overall, it's been a very good year. On the whole, it turned out to be a success. Generally speaking, we are very pleased with the progress. We were particularly impressed with how the project was managed. I was pleased with the results. I thought it went well. I managed to get the supplier to agree to a revised delivery schedule. As a result, we cut costs by 15 percent.
Discussing what didn't go well	What areas do you think need to be improved? So, what was the issue with the production line? Can you tell me exactly what went wrong? Why didn't we contact the client? The main issue was changes in the exchange rate. The problem was due to misunderstanding the schedule. Speaking openly, I think we should have planned better. My big challenge was meeting the deadlines.
Focusing on lessons learned	How can we organise things differently next time? What measures can we take to stop this happening again? Next time we need to improve communication. Next time I would arrange a briefing meeting at the start of the project. We now know that we need to plan more carefully. I'm confident that we can learn from this.

Closing a meeting

Summing up	That's all we have time for today. Let's sum up the main points. To recap, we've agreed to work on the project for six months and then review. We've discussed budgets and schedules, and agreed on the way forward.
Referring to action points and next steps	We'll meet again next week to discuss progress. We look forward to hearing updates at the next meeting. Is everyone clear on what they need to do? James, could you get a copy of the report to everyone by Thursday?
Closing	Thank you for coming, everyone. It was a very productive meeting. We made good progress today. Thank you for your contribution and ideas. Thank you all for your input today.